Vivien

By Percy Granger

(A man sits on a bench, his mouth is slack and his eyes are glazed. He stops. No movement. A younger man enters. He stops and peers at the seated figure.)

PAUL: Dad? *(No response; the man does not look at him.)* Dad? It's Paul. *(No response.) Dad. . .* Mr. Howard. . . Vivien? *(Vivien looks at him.)* Hi. *(No response.)* You been waiting long? *(No response.)* I'm sorry about the rain.

VIVIEN: *(looking away):* Weather doesn't bother me.

PAUL: Are you all set to go? *(No response. Paul takes a step forward.)* Can I give you a hand?

VIVIEN: Keep your distance.

PAUL: What's the matter?

VIVIEN: I'm not going with you. You're not Paul.

PAUL: Yes I am. It's Paul. *{Vivien begins to tremble slightly.}* Are you cold? Should we get in the car?

VIVIEN: I'm not getting in your car. You're not Paul.

PAUL: Sure I'm Paul. Of course, I'm Paul. It's me. Who else would I be?

VIVIEN: That's your problem.

PAUL: Are you Vivien Howard?

VIVIEN: Yes.

PAUL: I'm Paul Howard, I'm your son. *(No response.)* I know it's been a long time; I'm just grown up now. It's still me. *(No response.)* Norristown, you remember? It was just like today, it was raining. We sat in the parking lot. Mom went in and got you. You sat in the back seat. You stared at me, do you remember that? It was 1955, I was ten. I was just ten.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Paul's father, Vivien, has been kept medicated and in a maximum security mental institution for the past 30 years.*

ACTOR 2: *Having only a vague memory of his visiting his father when he was 10 years old and without any assistance from his mother, Paul has finally tracked Vivien down and plans to take him to the opening night of a play he is directing.*

ACTOR 1: *This scene opens as Paul leaves the hospital's main office to reunite with his father.*

ACTOR 2: *The distance between the two and Vivien's struggle with mental illness makes bridging the father/son gap a formidable task in . . .*

TOGETHER: *Vivien by Percy Granger*

VIVIEN: Everyone I know is dead.

PAUL: I spoke to-Mrs. Tedesco. She said you were very excited.

VIVIEN: I'm all right.

PAUL: I mean we made all the arrangements. She said you wanted to go out. *(No response.)* Look, it's starting to rain again, let's get in the car, okay? It's right over there

VIVIEN: No.

PAUL: Dad, it's after twelve, we've got to go.

VIVIEN: You go on. I'm sorry you drove all this way for nothing.

PAUL: *(taking out his wallet):* I can prove I'm Paul. There's my driver's license, there's my picture and my name. *(Vivien won't look.)* Look-I've got credit cards, union cards-I've got identification coming out of my ears!

VIVIEN: Don't show me your private property. Don't show me your private property! *(Pause.)*

PAUL: Can I sit down?

VIVIEN: It's a free country.

PAUL: *(sits next to him):* Paulie? Po? Pooh? I don't remember; what did you call me? *(No response.)* How are you?

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VIVIEN: I can't complain.

PAUL: You look terrific.

VIVIEN: You're not Paul.

PAUL: I am Paul! Why else would I be here?

VIVIEN: I'm supposed to meet Paul here.

PAUL: Okay-here, right? At the bus stop?

VIVIEN: Yes.

PAUL: In front of the buildings?

VIVIEN: Yes.

PAUL: On the bench?

VIVIEN: Yes.

PAUL: Okay, so here we are.

VIVIEN: Here we are.

PAUL: I'm your son.

VIVIEN: Go away. He's late.

PAUL: It's only twelve-fifteen.

VIVIEN: Late! There's going to be hell to pay. You stick around if you want to see some fireworks, mister. When he sees this son of his there's going to be hell to pay! He won't stand for it-he doesn't have to. He's got other recourses. He knows the score. There's a worm of truth there, you don't think so by your expression? You think he's just free?

PAUL: I didn't know where you were, all right? I had to fight with Mom to get her to tell me. I told her I had a right to know.

VIVIEN: I'm sure you're very busy.

PAUL: *(in a frenzy):* I rented a car, you want to see the papers? Here-see?-that's my signature! That's my handwriting! And look here, I got a letter from my wife, see? It's addressed to me! What else do you want? I know I'm Paul Howard, I

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paid a lot of money to an analyst to establish that fact! *(Vivien looks at him.)* So what I hear you saying is you don't want to come with me.

VIVIEN: I'm going to wait for Paul.

PAUL: Well, he won't come because that's me!

VIVIEN: Go away.

PAUL: We were supposed to spend the day together!

VIVIEN: *(rising, advancing on Paul):* Go away! Scat!

PAUL: Dad

VIVIEN: Shoo!

PAUL: *(backing up, frightened):* Hey Dad, come on, okay?

VIVIEN: Sssss!

PAUL: Take it easy

VIVIEN: *(makes a large gesture with his arms; roars):* Aaaaaaaah! *(He turns and walks off with a jerky, stiff-legged stride.)*

PAUL: *(angry):* Why'd you say yes then if you didn't want to come? Why'd you make me rent a car and drive all the way down here? Why'd you make me come?! *(sullenly)* I'm going. I'm sorry it didn't work out.

VIVIEN: You were right about the rain. I'm soaked to the marrow. You look dank too.

PAUL: *(grudgingly):* Do you want a lift back to your building? *(Beat.)*

VIVIEN: I've changed my mind.

PAUL: *(looks at him; freezes):* What?

VIVIEN: I've decided it will be all right to go with you.

PAUL: You have? Do you think you should?

VIVIEN: I think I can trust you. *(taking a pass from his pocket):* Here's my pass. We need to show it to the guard at the gate.

PAUL: This rain's going to make it tough.

VIVIEN: So much the better. *(Paul, not knowing what else to do, takes the pass and puts*

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the car in motion. After a few awkward moments of silence he nods out the window.)

PAUL: Are you sure you feel up to this?

VIVIEN: *(excitedly):* There's the gate! *(In a conspiratorial tone.)* Act normal. Don't worry about me, I'll sit still so they can't see me. I'm still pretty good at that. *(Paul, more nervous than ever, brings the car to a halt by the gate, rolls down the window and shows the pass. Vivien sits rigidly but his face is fairly bursting with excitement; out of the side of his mouth to Paul)* Go! go! *(Startled, Paul accelerates. Vivien clenches his fists and rocks slightly.)*

PAUL: It's just that I'm a little nervous. The critics are coming tonight. They don't count for much out here but still-(He *breaks off because Vivien has taken the pass and is slowly, triumphantly, tearing it up.)*

VIVIEN: Paul will sure be surprised when he shows up and I'm not there. *(Paul stops the car abruptly.)* What's the matter?

PAUL: Who am I?

VIVIEN: We met at the bus stop.

PAUL: What's my name?

VIVIEN: We had a long talk.

PAUL: We're not going anywhere until you admit who I am.

VIVIEN: You want me to get out?

PAUL: No! Who am I?

VIVIEN: The little lost sheep.

PAUL: Dad

VIVIEN: We're going to a play, is that right? I've been to a play before. They did a lopped-off Shakespeare for our benefit once.

PAUL: You want me to tell you about it?

VIVIEN: I remember it pretty well.

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PAUL: I mean the one we're going to now.

VIVIEN: Oh. Just a little bit. But not the ending.

PAUL: It's called *The Seagull.* It's about a group of people living in a summer house in Russia about 1890.

VIVIEN: I have to go to the bathroom.

PAUL: What? *(No response; Vivien's face contorts.)* You do? *(No response.)* Badly?

VIVIEN: I don't know yet.

PAUL: Can you hold it? If we stop we'll be late.

VIVIEN: I think I can do something with it. *(He lifts off the seat slightly and grunts ambiguously. Then he sits back. Pause.)*

PAUL: Wha-ah, what'd you do?

VIVIEN: I got it, don't worry. *(to himself):* I'm not going to drop my trousers on an Interstate.

PAUL: Jesus! Look, why don't I just turn on the radio, okay? You can listen to some music, would you like that?

VIVIEN: If you think it would help. *(Paul, chagrined, does not turn it on. They drive in silence several moments.)* There's another motel. Are we going to check into a motel tonight?

PAUL: No.

VIVIEN: I'm not going back.

PAUL: What? Of course you are.

VIVIEN: Who told you I was going back?

PAUL: You have to be back by

VIVIEN: I don't have to do anything, you got that, mister?

PAUL: But I promised I'd bring you back, that was the deal.

VIVIEN: You can't. There'd be reprisals.

PAUL: Reprisals?

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VIVIEN: Yes.

PAUL: What do you mean?

VIVIEN: There would.

PAUL: Against whom?

VIVIEN: Me.

PAUL: Why?

VIVIEN: I was trying to change doctors; they don't like that. My current doctor is old and cynical; he doesn't have anything to lose anymore. I'd written three letters to a new Jamaican doctor named Sohkey. He acts like he hasn't received them. If he's been forced to show them to the authorities he's curtains.

PAUL: Can't you talk to Miss Tendesco? She seems reasonable.

VIVIEN: She puts on a good show for the outsiders because we're her bread and butter, but in her heart of hearts she's a leopard.

PAUL: How would you live?

VIVIEN: I'll forage.

PAUL: What about your medication?

VIVIEN: I don't need it. I'm always okay once I get away from that place.

PAUL: Where would you go?

VIVIEN: Back to veterinary school. I'll get some clothing to improve my appearance. Professor Milton Dornhoffer said there'd always be a place for me.

PAUL: Have you written to him? *(Beat.)*

VIVIEN: I don't want to talk about it with you. *(He begins to rock back and forth violently; Paul clutches the steering wheel with both hands.)* I'm tired of being in this car with you. I don't have enough room. Stop.

PAUL: I can't.

VIVIEN: I want to get out.

PAUL: It's raining.

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VIVIEN: I'll be all right.

PAUL: We're going too fast.

VIVIEN: I want to get out.

PAUL: No. This is our day together.

VIVIEN: I don't make deals, mister.

PAUL: I'm not letting you out of this car.

VIVIEN: If you love me you won't take me back. *(Pause.)*

PAUL: I have to take you back. I'm sorry. . . *(Pause.)*

VIVIEN: It's stopped raining. *(Paul nods. Vivien leans forward and gazes up at the sky)* This is a good place to be for rainbows too. *(Brief pause; Vivien indicates the pad and the windshield.)* I used to sit like this with my father. He let me sit beside him in the front seat and keep the windshield clean.

PAUL: Were you close to him?

VIVIEN: *(grins)*: "Cheek by jowl." He used to take me on long trips. We went to the Chicago World's Fair-"The Century of Progress" they were still calling it then-and Florida, and Michigan. Ocean Boulevard. . . Once we drove all the way to New Mexico. My mother had to sit in the back seat.

PAUL: What did he do for a living?

VIVIEN: He operated a steam shovel, dredged the Mississippi. Oh yeah. We were river rats. Played poker, ate ice cream, drank whiskey, rented rooms. . . . He took us everywhere.

PAUL: What was his name?

VIVIEN: Edgar.

PAUL: What was your mother's name? *(Pause. Vivien's brow furrows. He does not want to talk about her.)*

VIVIEN: Dougal. *(Beat.)*

PAUL: It's just that Mom never told me anything about you. The only thing I ever

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remember her saying was once that you liked the out-of-doors.

VIVIEN: That's right. I could disappear for days into the mountains and no one would know where I was. Bang! I'm gone. I was alone on a mountain one day when I made a discovery. If I stared long enough at the landscape and sat very still, I could blend in with it. I could disappear. The forest animals would go on about their business as if I wasn't there. And the birds would sing different songs, not the ones they sang when people were around. I was no one and that made me special.

PAUL: Sounds wonderful.

VIVIEN: The trouble was when I started doing it around the house. *(Pause.)* I don't do it anymore now. You get more conservative with age.

PAUL: Were you really studying to be a veterinarian? *(No response.)* How-how did you and Mom meet?

VIVIEN: I was in charge of the pets at the college. There weren't supposed to be any. She had a cat. *(Pause. A look of pain crosses his face.)* The confiscated animals were sent to the labs. *(Pause.)* She never told you even that?

PAUL: *(shakes his head; inaudibly):* No.

VIVIEN: She's very strong-minded, isn't she? *(Paul, unable to speak, just nods.)* Well I let her keep that cat I'll tell, you. The next thing you know she invited me home to meet her father. He was pretty imposing too, ate good food. She hoped he wouldn't approve but he took a shine to me because of my prospects which weren't bad. So I went along with it. *(Pause.)* Recently I've been interested in suspended animation, freezing people until you can find a cure for them. I think that's a good idea. *(Pause.)*

PAUL: Was it Mom- Was she the one who took you to Norristown?

VIVIEN: *(with great difficulty):* ... No. I went of my own free will.

PAUL: Why? *(Vivien tries to respond; cannot.)* I wish you'd tried, you know? I wish

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you'd tried harder. *(Long silence. Finally Vivien looks out the window.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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